MINUTES OF THE CLARE COUNTY BOARD OF COMMISSIONERS

Approved 10/21/2026

225 W. Main St.
Harrison, Michigan 48625

~~Unapproved~~ minutes
September 16, 2026

Meeting was called to order at 9:00 a.m.

Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America

District 1 Marlene Housler, District 2 Bob Keasey, District 4 Jeff Haskell, District 5 David Hoefling, District 6 Jack Kleinhardt, District 7 Gabe Ambrozaitis, District 8 George Gilmore and District 9 Rick Fancon

COMMISSIONERS ABSENT

District 3 Jacob Gross

OTHERS PRESENT

Clerk & Register of Deeds Lori Mott, Administrator Lori Phelps, Treasurer Jenny Beemer-Fritzinger, Deputy Clerk Isha Walter, members of the public and zoom participants

APPROVAL OF AGENDA

It was moved by Commissioner Ambrozaitis, seconded by Commissioner Fancon to approve the agenda as amended, **motion carried.**

APPROVAL OF MINUTES

It was moved by Commissioner Housler, seconded by Commissioner Ambrozaitis to approve the Board of Commissioners' Minutes of August 19, 2026 and the Board of Commissioners' Special Meeting Minutes of September 2, 2026, **motion carried**.

PUBLIC HEARING OPEN FOR THE 2027 BUDGET

Chairman Gilmore announced that the public hearing on Clare County's proposed 2027 Budget was open at 9:02 a.m.

GENERAL PUBLIC COMMENT

Several Clare County residents expressed concern regarding their addresses on West Long Lake Drive being changed from Drive to Road. The address change is causing significant issues affecting mail delivery, voter registration, emergency response and beyond. Administrator Phelps recently attended a meeting with several other organizations, and they are in the process of attempting to resolve the problem. Clare County Road Commission Manager Dewayne Rogers stated that there is a committee comprised of the Clare County Administration office, Equalization, 911 Dispatch and the Building Inspector to work on address corrections. He asked for the concerned residents to meet with him after the meeting for further discussion.

COMMUNICATIONS LIST

1. Correspondence from Jaynie Hoerauf – no discussion
2. Arthur Township Special Land Use Permit – no discussion
3. Medical Examiner Report - no discussion

PUBLIC HEARINGS/SPECIAL PRESENTATIONS

1. Eric Karbowski Michigan State University (MSU) Extension
   District 6 Director Eric Karbowski expressed gratitude for Clare County's continued support of MSU Extension. He gave a brief overview of the 2025 Clare County Annual Report and highlighted the rebuilding efforts of the Master Gardner Program. He also introduced Renee Sanders, the 4-H Program Coordinator who gave a report on recent 4-H events in Clare County.

2. Chairman George Gilmore – Tribute to Colleen Ritchie
   Chairman Gilmore read Resolution #26-15 which highlights Colleen Ritchie's 33 years of dedicated service to Clare County.

   Tribute Resolution
   It was moved by Commissioner Gilmore, seconded by Commissioner Ambrozaitis to approve Resolution #26-15 paying Special Tribute to Colleen Ritchie for her years of dedicated service to Clare County, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (8) being Commissioners Ambrozaitis, Fancon, Gilmore, Haskell, Hoefling, Housler, Keasey and Kleinhardt
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (1) being Commissioner Gross
   Motion carried.

ADMINISTRATOR'S REPORT

Administrator Lori Phelps reported that there are no legislative updates. The proposed budget, the State's Cybersecurity audit, open enrollment for the Blue Care Network insurance and all tasks related to closing the fiscal year are keeping the Administration office busy.

JUSTICE

None

HEALTH AND HUMAN SERVICES

None

PHYSICAL RESOURCES AND ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT

1. MSU Extension Agreement for Services
   It was moved by Commissioner Hoefling, seconded by Commissioner Housler to approve the Fiscal Year 2027 Agreement for Services with MSU Extension,
   Motion carried.

FINANCE AND ADMINISTRATION

1. Statutory Finance Committee
   It was moved by Commissioner Ambrozaitis, seconded by Commissioner Housler to approve Statutory Finance Committee meeting minutes of August 17, 2026, in the amount of $93,877.08 and minutes of August 31, 2026, in the amount of $19,317.63, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (8) being Commissioners Ambrozaitis, Fancon, Gilmore, Haskell, Hoefling, Housler, Keasey and Kleinhardt
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (1) being Commissioner Gross
   Motion carried.

FINANCE AND ADMINISTRATION - continued

2. Monthly Expenditures
It was moved by Commissioner Housler, seconded by Commissioner Fancon to approve the expenditures for the month of August 2026 in the amount of $2,079,811.76 with the General Fund expenditures totaling $1,181,528.17, roll call vote revealed:

Yeas: (8) being Commissioners Kleinhardt, Keasey, Housler, Hoefling, Haskell, Gilmore, Fancon and Ambrozaitis
Nays: (0)
Absent: (1) being Commissioner Gross
Motion carried.

3. Budget Adjustments
   a. It was moved by Commissioner Fancon, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to approve Budget Adjustment #26-154 in the amount of $65,000.00, Budget Adjustment #26-151 in the amount of $267,000.00, and Budget Adjustment #26-169 in the amount of $700,000.00, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (8) being Commissioners Ambrozaitis, Fancon, Gilmore, Haskell, Hoefling, Housler, Keasey and Kleinhardt
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (1) being Commissioner Gross
   Motion carried.

   b. It was moved by Commissioner Kleinhardt, seconded by Commissioner Housler to allow the County Administrator to approve all Budget Adjustments as necessary above $50,000.00 from now until the end of Fiscal Year 2026, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (8) being Commissioners Fancon, Gilmore, Hoefling, Keasey, Kleinhardt, Housler, Haskell and Ambrozaitis
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (1) being Commissioner Gross
   Motion carried.

4. I.T. Managed Services
It was moved by Commissioner Haskell, seconded by Commissioner Ambrozaitis to accept the proposal from Karhu for Technology Managed Services and allow the Administrator to sign the contract, roll call vote revealed:

Yeas: (8) being Commissioners Ambrozaitis, Fancon, Gilmore, Kleinhardt, Keasey, Housler, Hoefling and Haskell
Nays: (0)
Absent: (1) being Commissioner Gross
Motion carried.

PUBLIC HEARING CLOSED

1. Resolution Approving Appropriations Act
It was moved by Commissioner Keasey, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to approve Resolution #26-13, approving and adopting the County General Appropriation Act for Fiscal Year 2027, roll call vote revealed:

Yeas: (8) being Commissioners Ambrozaitis, Fancon, Gilmore, Haskell, Hoefling, Housler, Keasey and Kleinhardt
Nays: (0)
Absent: (1) being Commissioner Gross
Motion carried.

PUBLIC HEARING CLOSED - continued

2. Wage Compensation Resolution
   It was moved by Commissioner Hoefling, seconded by Commissioner Housler to approve Resolution #26-14, establishing Fiscal Year 2027 Compensation, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (8) being Commissioners Kleinhardt, Keasey, Housler, Hoefling, Haskell, Gilmore, Fancon and Ambrozaitis
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (1) being Commissioner Gross
   Motion carried.

TREASURER'S REPORT

Treasurer Jenny Beemer-Fritzinger provided all the statutory finance reports and stated that everything is reconciled up to this point. The local units have been busy with the recent summer taxes deadline and her office has been busy with tax adjustments from the July Board of Review. Treasurer Beemer-Fritzinger stated that the schoolhouse project is completed. There will be an open house with the State Land Bank and Lincoln Township Clerk Carol Majewski, invitations coming soon.

CLARE COUNTY ROAD COMMISSION

Manager Dewayne Rogers gave a report on the roadwork completed within the past month throughout Clare County. He stated that they recently purchased chip seal equipment so the Road Commissioner will be able to complete their own work. Lastly, he reported that next Monday they are officially moving to the new building. A grand opening is scheduled for September 30, 2026 from 11:00 a.m. to 2:00 p.m. and lunch will be provided.

CHAIRMAN'S REPORT

Chairman George Gilmore has attended his meetings and had nothing to report.

VICE CHAIRMAN'S REPORT

Vice Chairman Rick Fancon had no report.

COMMISSIONER'S REPORT

Commissioner Ambrozaitis had no report.

Commissioner Hoefling gave a brief report on the townships and committees he represents.

Commissioner Housler has attended her meetings and had nothing to report.

Commissioner Kleinhardt mentioned receiving a letter from the International Transmission Company (ITC) regarding a proposed transmission lines project.

Commissioner Haskell had no report.

Commissioner Keasey reported that a Short Term Rental ordinance went into effect in Lincoln Township on August 22, 2026.

PUBLIC COMMENT

A Clare County resident asked Commissioner Keasey for a copy of the Lincoln Township Short Term Rental Ordinance.

UNFINISHED BUSINESS

1. Closed Session
   It was moved by Commissioner Fancon, seconded by Commissioner Housler to go into closed session under section 8(e) of the Open Meetings Act, to discuss litigation in Butts v. Clare County, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (8) being Commissioners Ambrozaitis, Fancon, Gilmore, Haskell, Hoefling, Housler, Keasey and Kleinhardt
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (1) being Commissioner Gross
   Motion carried.

Entered into closed session at 9:41 a.m.
Back in open session at 10:24 a.m.

NEW BUSINESS

None

ADJOURNMENT

It was moved by Commissioner Housler, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to adjourn the meeting, **motion carried.**

Meeting adjourned at 10:24 a.m.

Lori Mott, Clerk
Clare County Board of Commissioners

George Gilmore, Chairman
Clare County Board of Commissioners